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The Odyssey (2026 film)

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The Odyssey	
 Theatrical release poster	
Directed by	Christopher Nolan
Screenplay by	Christopher Nolan
Based on	Homer's *Odyssey*
Produced by	• Emma Thomas

	• Christopher Nolan
Starring	• Matt Damon • Tom Holland • Anne Hathaway • Robert Pattinson • Lupita Nyong'o • Samantha Morton • Zendaya • Charlize Theron
Cinematography	Hoyte van Hoytema
Edited by	Jennifer Lame
Music by	Ludwig Göransson
Production companies	• Universal Pictures[1] • Syncopy[1]
Distributed by	Universal Pictures[1]
Release dates	• July 6, 2026 (Odeon Luxe Leicester Square) • July 17, 2026 (United States and United Kingdom)
Running time	173 minutes[2]
Countries	• United States

	• United Kingdom
Language	English
Budget	$250 million[3]
Box office	$1.559 billion[4][5]

The Odyssey is a 2026 epic action fantasy film written and directed by Christopher Nolan, who produced it with his wife Emma Thomas. An adaptation of Homer's ancient Greek epic poem the *Odyssey*, it stars an ensemble cast including Matt Damon, Tom Holland, Anne Hathaway, Robert Pattinson, Lupita Nyong'o, Samantha Morton, Zendaya, and Charlize Theron. In the film, Odysseus (Damon), the Greek king of Ithaca, undergoes a long and perilous journey home after the Trojan War and encounters mythical beings as he attempts to reunite with his wife Penelope (Hathaway).

Nolan began writing the script in March 2024 and secured the project with Universal Pictures by October. *The Odyssey* was announced in December. Casting took place from late 2024 through early 2025, and Damon was confirmed for the lead role in February 2025. Nolan studied several translations of the *Odyssey* before deciding upon a realistic interpretation of Greek mythology, drawing inspiration from the epic historical films *Andrei Rublev* (1966) and *Ran* (1985), as well as the films of special effects artist Ray Harryhausen. Filming took place on location from February to August 2025 in Morocco, Greece, Italy, Scotland, Iceland, Western Sahara, and Malta, as well as at the Universal Studios Lot in Los Angeles. With an estimated budget of $250 million, it is among the most expensive films of Nolan's career, and the first feature film to

be shot entirely on IMAX's 70 mm film cameras.

The Odyssey premiered at the Odeon Luxe Leicester Square in London on July 6, 2026, ahead of a theatrical release by Universal Pictures on July 17 in the United States and the United Kingdom. It was made available in IMAX and multiple premium large formats. The film received critical acclaim, with particular praise for Nolan's direction, but received some criticism for its deviations from the source material. It has grossed $1.559 billion worldwide, becoming the second-highest-grossing film of 2026, the highest-grossing R-rated film ever, and the fourteenth-highest grossing film of all time. It also became Nolan's highest-grossing film and set numerous records for him, including some premium-format pre-sales that were released a year in advance.

Plot

For twenty years, Ithaca has been without its king, Odysseus, unreturned from the Trojan War. Several suitors, including nobleman Antinous, aggressively court Odysseus's wife Penelope to claim the throne from Odysseus and Penelope's son Telemachus. Only Penelope, Telemachus, and Odysseus' half-blind servant Eumaeus still believe Odysseus will return. Penelope tells Telemachus she fears attacks by murderous "people from the sea" who violate Zeus's law—mutual respect between guests and hosts. Telemachus travels with Odysseus's friend Mentor, to Menelaus, King of Sparta, to ascertain his father's whereabouts. Antinous learns about this and conspires to kill Telemachus upon his return and plunder Ithaca. Menelaus and his wife Helen tell Telemachus about the war, but express uncertainty about Odysseus's fate.

Meanwhile, the goddess Athena appears to Odysseus on the island of Ogygia, where the nymph Calypso is infatuated with Odysseus. Athena commands Odysseus to return home; Calypso dislikes this, but encourages Odysseus to remember his past. Years earlier, the Greek army, led by Menelaus' brother Agamemnon, conquered Troy using Odysseus' stratagem, the Trojan Horse, hiding Greeks inside, with Sinon sacrificed as a decoy. While Menelaus and Agamemnon returned home, Odysseus and his crew, including second-in-command Eurylochus, searched for an island for supplies, but the cyclops Polyphemus traps them in a cave, and devours several soldiers. They blind Polyphemus and escape, but hear him cry out to his father Poseidon; the crew suffers harsh sea conditions. They land on Aeaea, where giant Laestrygonians kill most of them and sink two of their three ships. The survivors rebel, leaving Odysseus with their ship as they seek refuge with the witch Circe, who turns them into pigs. After Odysseus persuades her to change his men back, Circe warns that to reach Ithaca, Odysseus must cross Oceanus into the Land of the Dead.

There, Odysseus meets his fallen soldiers, including Sinon's shade, who reproaches him for deceiving him, and reveals that Antinous manipulated him into taking his place in the Greek army. Next, Agamemnon's shade reveals that his wife Clytemnestra murdered him upon his return as revenge for sacrificing their daughter Iphigenia to Artemis for fair seas; he advises that Odysseus adopt a disguise upon returning home. Finally, Odysseus alone speaks with the shade of Tiresias, who predicts that, by divine will, only Odysseus will return home.

Chased from the Land of the Dead by Odysseus' fallen army,

Odysseus follows Tiresias' guidance to survive encounters with the Sirens, and with Charybdis and Scylla. On Thrinacia, Odysseus warns his men not to kill the cattle of the Sun God, as Tiresias foretold Odysseus' men would die if they did, but the starving men disobey. When they leave, Zeus's storm sinks their ship, killing all but Odysseus. He washes ashore unconscious on Ogygia; Calypso's lotus flowers allow Odysseus to forget Troy and his soldiers and family.

After seven years, he builds a raft and surrenders his fate to the storm. He washes ashore in Ithaca; Eumaeus tells him the suitors sent bandits to assassinate Telemachus and Mentor at Athena's temple; Odysseus goes there. Mentor dies, but a disguised Odysseus, calling himself "Sinon", kills the bandits, rescuing Telemachus. The pair return to Ithaca. Odysseus's elderly dog Argos dies as he recognizes Odysseus, and Telemachus realizes Odysseus's identity. During a feast, Odysseus confronts Antinous about betraying Sinon. Antinous thrashes Odysseus before Telemachus intervenes.

After the meal, Odysseus, still disguised, confesses to Penelope his guilt for violating Zeus' law during the sacking of Troy, desecrating Athena's statue after killing her priestess (whose form Athena assumed in visions), and initiating the collapse of the Bronze Age. He reveals that the "sea people" were the Greeks themselves, and begs Penelope's forgiveness. Athena appears to him, clasping his hand. Penelope announces her readiness to remarry and instructs the suitors to return at dawn.

Penelope declares she will marry whoever can string Odysseus' bow and shoot an arrow through a row of axe heads. The suitors fail. Odysseus succeeds, thereby revealing his identity; the hall